

“Crest toothpaste is on sale for \$1, and Sunday’s newspaper had \$1 coupons in it!” I’d announce, brimming with excitement at the prospect of free toothpaste.

“I already have a tube of toothpaste,” came the perplexed reply.

More than once, I began a conversation detailing a recent shopping trip or the latest great deal, only to abruptly stop talking when I saw my companion’s eyes glaze over. Gradually it dawned on me that not everyone else was thrilled by free shampoo and toothpaste. In fact, I realized, while my hobby seemed tedious to some, it was downright bizarre to others.

Was I actually that weird, that different from the average consumer? I knew there were other women like me, who were just as crazy about couponing as I was. I traded with some, and saw others in the grocery store aisles with their coupons. I read about them in the refund magazines I subscribed to. But, admittedly, among my family and friends, I was an oddity.

What was it about couponing and refunding that appealed to me, and not to others? What got me started in this incredibly rewarding hobby? Certainly my mother had used a few coupons but never to any great extent. For one thing, she and my father could barely afford the newspapers or magazines that carried the coupons. As parents raising ten children on a low income, they struggled just to put food on the table and clothes on our backs. My father raised chickens for their eggs and meat and planted and tended a huge garden every year. My mother canned or froze their abundant harvest, sewed many of our clothes, made our dolls, braided rag rugs, and gutted the chickens that became a staple of our Sunday dinners.